On October 26, Nehru sent Kennedy (and leaders of other like-minded countries) a letter asking for "sympathy and support."[244] Indian officials also expressed hope that the US would restrain Pakistan—which was making "pro-Chinese noises"—from taking any action to open a second front.[245]

By this point, Nehru was aware not just of the looming threat but also that the Soviet Union was backing China. Khrushchev was "not happy" with the situation, but by October 13, he had declared to Chinese officials his support for his Chinese "brothers" rather than his Indian "friends." He had asserted, "[I]n relations between us there is no place for neutrality." Khrushchev had also delayed the delivery of MiGs to India. Unbeknownst to Delhi, the Soviet Union would also share intelligence on India with China, and provide it details of India-Soviet discussions and correspondence.

The Indian government did know that Moscow was supporting Beijing thanks to Khrushchev's letters to Nehru on October 20 and October 31, and the Soviet position at the UN urging India to negotiate with China.[246] The Indian prime minister asserted to the Soviet leader that the crisis was due to China's "deliberate aggressive moves," and not the US. He saw Khrushchev's allegation as an attempt to keep Delhi from turning to Washington.[247] On October 23, M. J. Desai had told Galbraith that Moscow was taking a "tough line" with Delhi and was unlikely to restrain Beijing.[248] Then, on October 25, *Pravda* had publicly called for India to accept Chinese terms on the border.[249] A subsequent piece in early November after the Cuban missile crisis had ended seemed more moderate, urging negotiations without mentioning the Chinese conditions. Nonetheless, for the rest of the war, Nehru did not expect Moscow's help; he could only hope that it would not assist China.[250]

The US, on the other hand, had announced at the onset of the war that it would consider "sympathetic[ally]" any Indian request for aid.[251] With the situation deteriorating, on October 27 it declared that it "recognized the McMahon Line as the traditional and generally accepted international border and fully supported India's position in that regard." Furthermore, Kennedy responded to Nehru's letter, saying the US wanted to give "support as well as sympathy" and stood ready to discuss India's practical needs.[252]